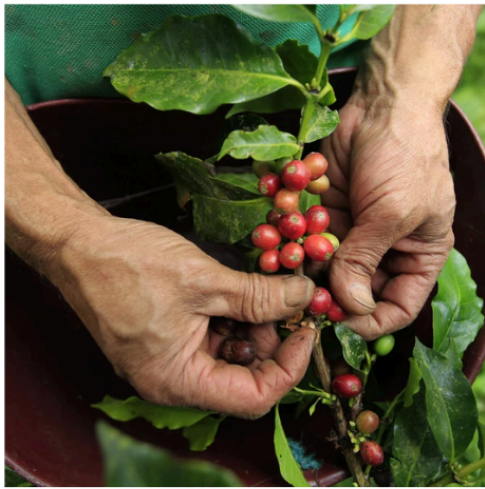


Promoting Justice-Oriented International Development

Lessons from USAID's
CELI N/S Project in Colombia



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Introduction: Vision, Goals, and Objectives

In the last two decades, there has been an industry-wide increase in the concept of “localization,” which emphasizes “put[ting] local actors in the lead, strengthen[ing] local systems, and [being] responsive to local communities.”¹ However, power dynamics of dominance continue to be ignored in localization frameworks used by large development organizations and agencies.

As such, we have come together as a collective of implementation-focused development practitioners to innovate localization processes to be more racially just and equitable.

Our vision is a development industry that uses localization frameworks which emphasize racial justice and equity-based approaches. These frameworks would account for the local context and subvert local power structures. We imagine a larger change in the development ecosystem where marginalized peoples are given the financial, economic, and social autonomy to decide on their community’s priorities and what actions will best address these priorities. Our team has adopted three guiding objectives to enable this vision:



Challenge oppressive power structures through the restructuring of development project mechanisms.



Foster sustainable and inclusive futures through power-sharing structures and community autonomy in decision-making.



Challenge development organizations to reflect on their positionality and their role in upholding historically colonial power dynamics.

Ultimately, our goal is to establish development as a tool for liberation, centering marginalized communities as knowledge experts that can advocate for their own priorities. To achieve this, we have undertaken a case study of the USAID funded Chemonics International project that was touted a localization success – “Consolidation and Enhanced Livelihoods Initiative - Northern/Southern Regions” (CELI N/S) based in Colombia. We use learnings from this case to

¹ U.S. Agency For International Development. “Localization | What We Do | U.S. Agency for International Development,” July 10, 2024.
<https://www.usaid.gov/localization#:~:text=At%20USAID%2C%20localization%20is%20the,is%20responsive%20to%20local%20communities>.

propose our own localization framework that incorporates power-sharing mechanisms as well as reflexivity practices at every step of the development project cycle.

CELI/NS: Project Context

Project Overview

CELI N/S was implemented from 2014 to 2017, targeting 19 conflict-affected municipalities across Antioquia, Bolívar, Córdoba, and Tumaco (Nariño).⁷ The initiative aimed to promote rural development, economic inclusion, and stabilization in regions severely impacted by armed conflict and weak state presence.⁷ Key efforts included strengthening local governance, improving infrastructure, fostering licit livelihoods, and supporting marginalized groups, such as Afro-Colombian and Indigenous communities, to address systemic inequities and build sustainable economic opportunities.⁷

Country Context

Our team conducted a country context analysis to examine how effectively CELI N/S accounted for local power structures within its project activities. We identified race, gender, and indigeneity as three of the major factors affecting communities in the project's working districts.

Afro-Colombian regions have been largely abandoned by the state, leaving communities to face extreme violence from armed groups, land dispossession, and enforced displacement.² Indigenous peoples face a similar struggle as public and private sector actors engage in land grabbing under the guise of promoting national development.³ Administrative and judicial processes that would legalize indigenous land as ethnic collective property have come to a

² OHCHR. "Colombia Must Be Accountable to People of African Descent in Conditions of Risk and 'Resistance', Say UN Experts." United Nations Human Rights Office of the High Commissioner, May 24, 2024.

<https://www.ohchr.org/en/press-releases/2024/05/colombia-must-be-accountable-people-african-descent-conditions-risk-and>.

³ Bratspies, Rebecca. "'Territory Is Everything': Afro-Colombian Communities, Human Rights and Illegal Land Grabs – Columbia Human Rights Law Review," May 27, 2020.

<https://hrlr.law.columbia.edu/hrlr-online/territory-is-everything-afro-colombian-communities-human-rights-and-illegal-land-grabs/>.

standstill.⁴ Afro-Colombian and Indigenous women face the greatest threats to their land rights, constituting over half of the displaced population within their communities⁵ with sexual and gender-based violence being used as an instrument of displacement.⁶

CELI/NS: Intersectional Justice Analysis

Governance

The project revealed shortcomings in empowering grassroots actors. The priorities of the project were determined by USAID, Chemonics, and the Colombian government, aligning primarily with the government's goals to strengthen their presence in conflict affected regions. This top-down approach sidelines the voices of Indigenous and Afro-Colombian communities, and didn't incorporate an analysis of the areas with the highest needs. In addition, there was no mention of accountability systems in place for Chemonics to address or rectify potential harms caused to communities during the project.

Funding

CELI N/S, was funded with \$55.1 million by USAID and an additional \$207.3 million through a co-financing scheme.⁷ The project's grants allowed grassroots organizations to lead infrastructure projects, fostering local ownership and capacity building.⁷ However, disparities in regional funding highlighted inequities: Tumaco, a predominantly Afro-Colombian municipality, received only \$14.9 million, while Antioquia received \$36.2 million, despite Tumaco's higher levels of poverty and violence.⁸ Additionally, bureaucratic requirements for grant access posed

⁴ IWGIA. "The Indigenous World 2023: Colombia - IWGIA - International Work Group for Indigenous Affairs." IWGIA - International Work Group for Indigenous Affairs, March 27, 2023. <https://www.iwgia.org/en/colombia/5082-iw-2023-colombia.html>.

⁵ Bratspies, "Territory Is Everything': Afro-Colombian Communities, Human Rights and Illegal Land Grabs – Columbia Human Rights Law Review."

⁶ Bratspies, "Territory Is Everything': Afro-Colombian Communities, Human Rights and Illegal Land Grabs – Columbia Human Rights Law Review."

⁷ United States Agency for International Development (USAID). *Consolidation and Enhanced Livelihoods Initiative – Northern/Southern Regions (CELI N/S) Final Report*. Prepared by Chemonics International Inc., October 31, 2017.

⁸ United States Agency for International Development (USAID). *Consolidation and Enhanced Livelihoods Initiative – Northern/Southern Regions (CELI N/S) Final Report*. Prepared by Chemonics International Inc., October 31, 2017.

challenges for some grassroots organizations, undermining the project's goal of locally-led development.⁹

Advocacy and Organizing

Key advocacy and organizing efforts within CELI N/S included gender violence campaigns (2014–2016) aimed at elevating awareness. However, these campaigns did not focus on initiatives that directly addressed systemic inequities or building long-term capacity for advocacy. Funding could have been directed to organizations such as *Casa de la Mujer*¹⁰ and *Corporación Humanas*,¹¹ which implement programs that amplify women's voices, build their leadership capacities, and address structural barriers to equality.

Infrastructure and Agriculture

CELI N/S completed 347 infrastructure projects to improve connectivity and access to services.¹² The project strengthened cacao and coffee value chains by supporting producer associations like Chocolate Tumaco, while promoting alternative licit livelihoods through crop production. Additionally, technical training and capacity-building initiatives helped improve agricultural productivity and foster local expertise.¹³

However, farmers were largely confined to low-value production, selling cacao pods and coffee cherries with minimal access to processing infrastructure or value-added markets.¹⁴ The project failed to address power imbalances in trade, leaving producers vulnerable to exploitative

⁹ United States Agency for International Development (USAID). *Consolidation and Enhanced Livelihoods Initiative – Northern/Southern Regions (CELI N/S) Final Report*. Prepared by Chemonics International Inc., October 31, 2017.

¹⁰ *Casa de la Mujer*. "Nuestra Historia." Accessed December 20, 2024.
<https://www.casamujer.org.co/nuestra-historia>.

¹¹ *Corporación Humanas*. "Quiénes Somos." Accessed December 20, 2024.
<https://www.humanas.org.co/quienes-somos>.

¹² United States Agency for International Development (USAID). *Consolidation and Enhanced Livelihoods Initiative – Northern/Southern Regions (CELI N/S) Final Report*. Prepared by Chemonics International Inc., October 31, 2017.

¹³ United States Agency for International Development (USAID). *Consolidation and Enhanced Livelihoods Initiative – Northern/Southern Regions (CELI N/S) Final Report*. Prepared by Chemonics International Inc., October 31, 2017.

¹⁴ Lehnis, Marianne. "Colombia's Largest Coffee Company Goes Big to Grow Green." *Forbes*, September 18, 2023.

intermediaries.¹⁵ The lack of long-term maintenance plans for infrastructure projects also raises concerns about their sustainability. In addition, marginalized communities were not explicitly represented on governance boards of infrastructure projects such as road construction.¹⁶

Land

The project supported the designation of 6,982 property titles for low-income populations and diploma training of 180 grassroots leaders in land formalization.¹⁷ CELI N/S promoted social equity and power sharing by advancing land tenure rights in Afro-Colombian and Indigenous communities.

However, the project provided no details on land displacement that may have occurred due to its infrastructure projects. Colombia has a history of infrastructure projects resulting in land-grabbing and displacement of families.¹⁸ For example, the hydroelectric project in El Peñol and Guatapé in 1970 resulted in flooding of rural towns, resettlement of many families, and failed promises of home reconstructions.¹⁹

This intersectional justice analysis of the CELI/NS project has informed our new development framework that we describe below.

Our Justice-Oriented Framework Proposal

Key Existing Frameworks and Approaches

In developing our new framework, we have conducted a literature review of strong localization and anti-racism frameworks. The Overseas Development Institute's report, "Are We There Yet?"

¹⁵ Jacobi, Johanna, Derly Lara, Sebastian Opitz, Sabine de Castelberg, Sergio Urioste, Alvaro Irazoque, Daniel Castro, Elio Wildisen, Nelson Gutierrez, and Chahan Yeretian. "Making Specialty Coffee and Coffee-Cherry Value Chains Work for Family Farmers' Livelihoods: A Participatory Action Research Approach." *World Development Perspectives* 33 (March 2024)

¹⁶ United States Agency for International Development (USAID). *Consolidation and Enhanced Livelihoods Initiative – Northern/Southern Regions (CELI N/S) Final Report*. Prepared by Chemonics International Inc., October 31, 2017.

¹⁷ Ibid.

¹⁸ Lopes, Cindia Arango. "A Town amid the Waters: The Building of a Hydroelectric Dam in Eastern Antioquia, Colombia." University Blog Service – University of Texas at Austin, September 27, 2022. <https://sites.utexas.edu/lilas-benson-magazine/2022/09/27/a-town-amid-the-waters-the-building-of-a-hydroelectric-dam-in-eastern-antioquia-colombia/>.

¹⁹ Ibid.

Localisation as the Journey Towards Locally Led Practice,” distinguishes “localization” as a process leading to “locally led” programs, highlighting disparities between donors, international, national, and local actors.²⁰ The report also critiques the term “local” for masking internal power dynamics and offers a framework of three dimensions (resources, agency, ways of being) and five levers (decision-making, priorities, knowledge, relationships, delivery). Bond’s framework²¹ and the Racial Equity Index²² complement this by addressing systemic racism, decolonization, and equity, which informed our framework’s equity-centered guided questions.

Our Proposal: The LOTUS Framework

We developed the LOTUS Framework, providing a justice-oriented approach to development that prioritizes local leadership, equity, and sustainability throughout all stages of project planning and implementation.

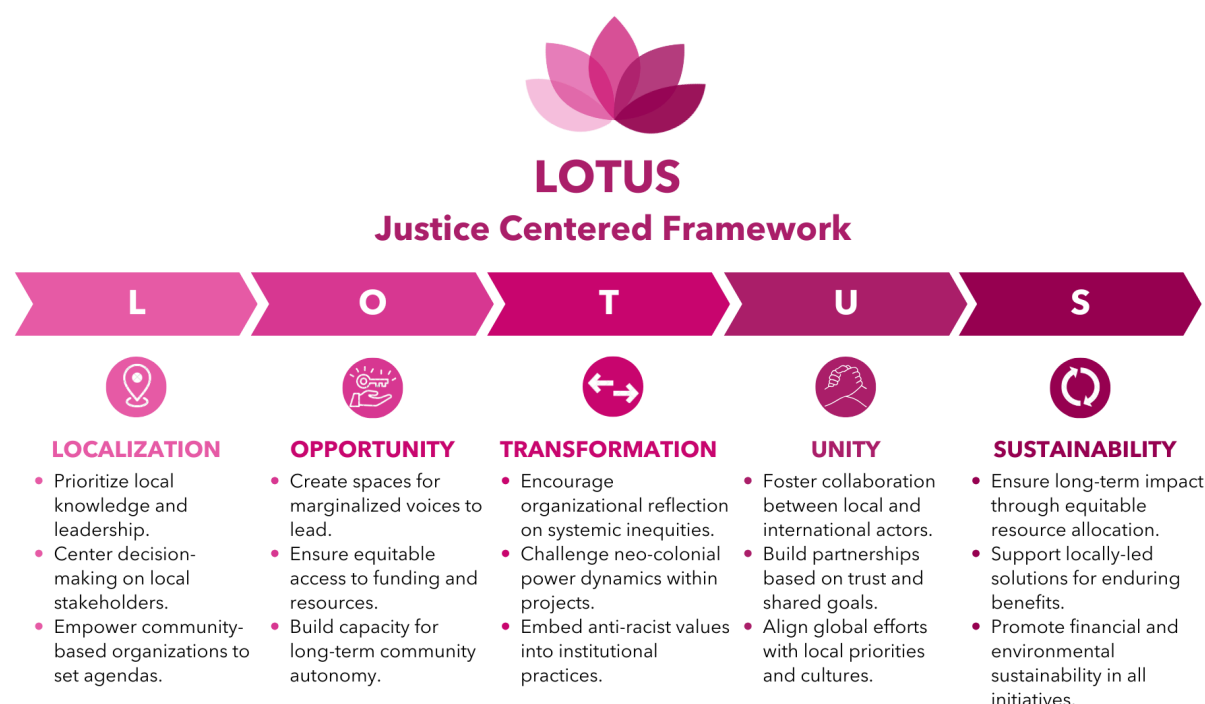


Diagram 1: LOTUS Framework

²⁰ Baguios, A., King, M., Martins, A. and Pinnington, R. (2021) *Are we there yet? Localisation as the journey towards locally led practice: models, approaches and challenges*. ODI Report. London: ODI [Link](#). 15-16.

²¹ The Social Investment Consultancy (TSIC) and Bond. 2022. *Becoming Locally Led Asbecoming Locally Led As An Anti-Racist Practice: A Guide To Support INGOs*. Guide. A Journey towards Locally Led Development: A Guide to Support INGOs. Bond. [Link](#).

²² The Racial Equity Index and Moore Impact. 2021. “The Global Mapping Survey Full Data Release 2nd Edition.” [Link](#). 11.

The framework is built around the five pillars shown in Diagram 1 and integrates 3 axes of analysis to examine and address power dynamics at every stage of the project cycle:

- **Governance:** decision-making power and accountability structures.
- **Funding:** equitable resource allocation
- **Impact:** contextualization and alignment with community-defined priorities.

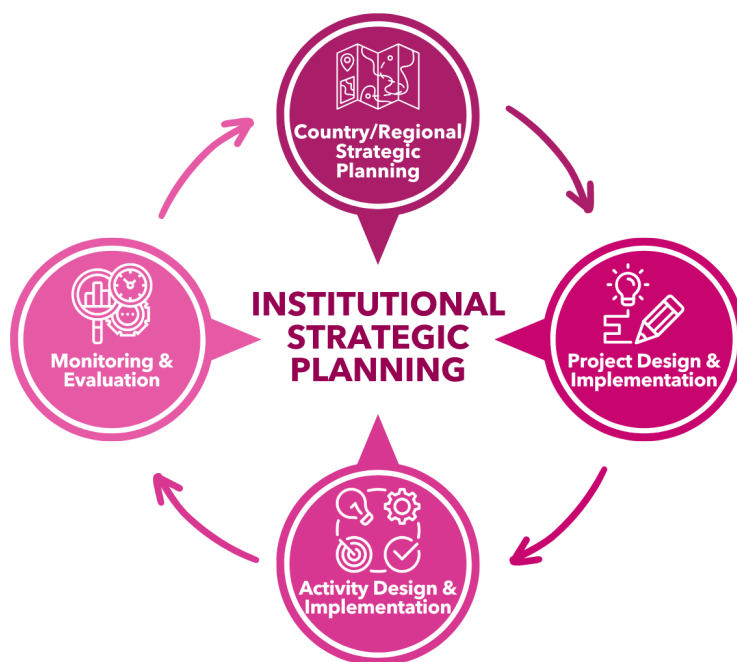


Diagram 2: Development Project Cycle

LOTUS incorporates key guiding questions and strategies at every stage of the project cycle (see diagram 2) to ensure that development practitioners are considering critical issues of racial justice and equity within the organization and project's governance, funding, and impact. Drawing from Neha Kagal and Lia Latchford's "Towards an Intersectional Praxis in International Development", we prioritized institutional strategic planning as the first step in the framework. By starting at the institutional level, we aim to encourage organizations to reflect on their positionality and examine how racialized preconceptions and biases shape their decisions about the communities they serve.²³ Grappling with these questions creates a foundation for advancing racial justice and fostering inclusive organizational cultures that will align projects with the needs of communities.

²³ Neha Kagal & Lia Latchford. 2020. "Towards an Intersectional Praxis in International Development: what can the sector learn from Black feminists located in the global North?", *Gender and Development*, 28:1, 11.

Please refer to Tables 1.1-1.5 in the appendix for the details of the framework.

Key Agents of Change and Risks

Development practitioners at implementation organizations are the key agents of change central to achieving our proposed framework. Senior leaders are critical for driving institutional transformation, reallocating resources, and sharing decision-making power with marginalized groups. In addition, program managers integrate local voices and priorities into project design and delivery.

However, development practitioners face risks, such as pushback from donors. Resistance to power-sharing often stems from concerns of local incompetency rooted in racialized tropes and paternalism. To mitigate these challenges, we can provide donors with data and evidence from impact assessments that demonstrate how racially-just localization fosters autonomy and self-reliance within communities, supported by qualitative feedback from locals, ultimately resulting in higher rates of development success.

Conclusion

Moving forward, we envision development practitioners at implementing organizations using this framework to bring racial equity, decolonial, and localization principles to their work. Our next steps include working with development organizations to pilot the framework, gathering feedback, and improving the framework through an iterative process. By building on lessons from CELI N/S and other frameworks, we aspire for the LOTUS Framework to be a racially-just framework that continues to evolve to meet the needs of communities across the world.

Appendix

Table 1.1: LOTUS: Institutional Strategic Planning Stage

Institutional Strategic Planning	
 Governance	1. Accountability mechanisms and organization culture: a. What accountability mechanisms exist within the organization to address racial inequities? i. Transparency and Reporting 1. Setting clear goals and targets for racial equity and providing periodic updates on progress 2. Regular collection and publishing of data on DEI within the leadership and workforce ii. Leadership accountability 1. Holding senior management accountable for achieving racial equity goals through regular evaluations b. How are BIPOC voices centered in organizational processes?²⁴ c. What mechanisms exist to prevent racial discrimination, gaslighting, and tokenism?²⁵ d. Are anti-racist values explicitly articulated and practiced?²⁶ 2. Analysis of current project approaches: a. What could have been improved in terms of power sharing and racial justice? 3. To what extent does the organization's structure perpetuate or challenge neo-colonial power dynamics?
 Funding	1. Donor Portfolio Assessment a. Examining the conditionality of funding i. Is the implementing organization restricted by funding conditionalities from their donors? How is this restricting possible project activities? b. What alternative funding sources (foundations/individual donors/etc) would give the organization the flexibility to grant inclusion and autonomy to beneficiaries within potential projects?
 Institutional Impact	1. Reflection workshops/support groups to take place prior to project design/implementation: a. Target demographic of workshops: i. Employees of the organization ii. Executives and board of directors b. Key focuses i. Exploration of employees' subjectivity, representations, power, and locatedness c. Potential questions to reflect on: i. What 'truths'/beliefs/biases do I hold about the populations I am working with and how does this influence my work? ii. What language is being used at the organizational and project levels? d. Small, in-person, facilitated mandatory workshops/support groups e. <u>BOND's matrix and guide for reflecting on best practice</u> can be used to support this process²⁷

Goal: To establish a foundation for justice-driven and equity-centered programming by thoughtfully analyzing institutional power dynamics and fostering an inclusive organizational culture.

²⁴ The Racial Equity Index [Link](#). 48.

²⁵ Ibid.

²⁶ Ibid. 59.

²⁷ Becoming Locally Led As Becoming Locally Led As An Anti-Racist Practice: A Guide To Support INGOs. [Link](#).

Table 1.2: LOTUS: Country/Regional Strategic Planning Stage

Country/Regional Strategic Planning	
 Governance	1. Analysis of the metrics that implementing organizations are using to identify working regions. a. What factors drive the organization's decision to prioritize certain countries or regions for assistance? i. Reflection by the board of directors and executive leadership on the organization's motivations for operating in certain regions b. To what extent are these decisions influenced by historical power imbalances, including colonial legacies? c. Are any implicit biases or racial assumptions shaping how needs are identified and framed? 2. Are they continuously revisiting and reworking their approaches to be more equitable?
 Funding	1. Is the funding structure at the country level aligned with long-term sustainability goals, or does it risk reinforcing existing power imbalances rooted in neo-colonial dynamics?²⁸
 Impact	1. How are implementing organizations setting their working priorities in those regions?²⁸ a. Are they consulting local, marginalized communities as knowledge experts? b. How do these priorities align with the perspectives and priorities of local communities? 2. Does the organization's strategy align with local systems and local cultures? Does it seek to change the country/region's culture and ways of being?²⁹

Goal: To ensure that country and regional strategies are equitable, racially just, and locally driven by critically examining decision-making processes, funding structures, and impact priorities to avoid perpetuating neo-colonial dynamics.

²⁸ Baguios, A., King, M., Martins, A. and Pinnington, R. (2021) 15-16.

²⁹ Ibid.

Table 1.3: LOTUS: Project Design & Implementation Stage

Project Design & Implementation	
 Governance	1. Decision-Making Through Power Sharing: a. To what extent are local organizations and actors involved in the project design? i. Are local knowledge holders brought on as expert consultants? b. Are local organizations able to set their own agendas and priorities? c. Stakeholder mapping i. Identifying power dynamics between international and local stakeholders, as well as amongst local stakeholders. ii. Community interviews 1. Ensuring locally based, trauma-informed facilitators are present during interviews and focus groups. d. Are local actors compelled to change their identity or approaches when engaging with international actors? 2. Leadership and Staffing: a. Are there racial, gender, or other power dynamics within the project team that may influence decision-making and project implementation? b. What measures are in place to ensure that project teams reflect the diversity of the populations they are working with? c. Are individuals from the target countries being hired directly by the contracted organization? i. If so, are they from historically privileged groups? ii. If they are from minoritized groups, what level of decision-making power and autonomy are they given? d. How does the composition of the leadership team influence the priorities, strategies, and perceptions of the project?
 Funding	1. How much money is allocated to overhead costs versus the program activities? a. Is there funding allocated for HQ staff to travel and oversee the project? b. Can this money be appropriately allocated to locally-led initiatives?
 Impact	1. Analysis of Power Dynamics in the Target Region to be Done Before Proposal Development/Project Design a. Define who is "local" and analyze power dynamics within the target region/country. i. Who is considered 'local'?³⁰ ii. What is being 'local' defined by? iii. Who is eligible for funding for 'local' actors? iv. Who is considered to have 'local' knowledge? v. Where is local? Among rural vs. urban communities? Immediate family? Diaspora, migrants and refugees? vi. Who is ultimately impacted by the localisation effort, and what is the extent of their involvement? 2. How are power dynamics influencing project outcomes at the local level?³¹ 3. To what extent does the project align with local systems, priorities, and identities?

Goal: To create a participatory, equitable, racially just, and sustainable project design and implementation process that centers local knowledge systems and holders as central to achieving long-term impact in line with community priorities

³⁰ Baguios, A., King, M., Martins, A. and Pinnington, R. (2021) 15-16.

³¹ Becoming Locally Led As Becoming Locally Led As An Anti-Racist Practice. [Link](#).

Table 1.4: LOTUS: Activity Design & Implementation Stage

Activity Design & Implementation	
 Governance	1. Do local community-based organizations and actors have a central role in deciding project activities? 2. Are individuals from the target countries being hired directly for activity implementation? a. If so, are they from privileged groups? b. What power do they hold in relation to the people who the project is seeking to support? c. If they are from minoritized groups/populations, are they given decision-making power/autonomy?
 Funding	1. Is the process for accessing funding inclusive and equitable for local organizations? 2. Are there mechanisms in place to ensure the long-term sustainability of project impacts after the end of the project?³² a. Potential strategies: i. Creating linkages between small-scale businesses and larger regional and national economic markets ii. Support building the infrastructure for alternative streams of funding, such as private sector impact investing, during the project b. How are the conditions of grants and funding shaping decisions on how and where money is spent? c. Is the renewal of funding contingent on specific project outcomes, and how does this influence long-term planning and local priorities?³³
 Impact	1. Are project activities in line with existing economic and socio-cultural systems? a. Do the project activities weaken or strengthen these existing systems? 2. Do project activities strengthen local systems, or do they risk undermining them by introducing external approaches and priorities? 3. Does the project create unintended consequences, such as dependency, disruption of local markets, or shifts in cultural norms? 4. Are positive impacts equitably distributed, particularly among marginalized groups within the target communities?

Goal: Ensure project activities are community-driven, inclusive, and sustainable by centering local organizations and individuals—especially those from minoritized groups—in decision-making and implementation.

³² The Racial Equity Index. 63.

³³ Baguios, A., King, M., Martins, A. and Pinnington, R. (2021) 29.

Table 1.5: LOTUS: Monitoring & Evaluation Stage

Monitoring & Evaluation	
 Governance	1. What is happening with the data collected through monitoring and evaluation? a. Is data collection used for the implementing organization to be accountable to the communities in the project's target region? 2. Is the M&E actually framed in a way that supports sustainable funding and funding allocation? 3. Whose priorities and preferences are used to define and measure success?³⁴ 4. In what direction does accountability flow? Are the organizations demonstrating accountability to the donors only?
 Funding	1. Monitoring and evaluation systems are often driven by donor requirements, which prioritize demonstrating success for continued funding, rather than ensuring accountability to project beneficiaries or addressing potential harm caused by the project.³⁵ a. Are there mechanisms in place that ensure that international development organizations demonstrate their responsibility to target populations? This can be done through: b. Independent Accountability Mechanisms (IAMs) can be put in place to allow beneficiaries to voice concerns and seek redress for potential harm caused by development initiatives. c. Multi-stakeholder Accountability (MSA) mechanisms: i. Access-to-information policies ii. Evaluation offices iii. Grievance redress systems iv. Public-private governance arrangements
 Impact	1. What do we mean by impact, and what constitutes success? Is there an implicit assumption that evaluation is about quantifiable targets? 2. How is evaluation conducted? Is it conducted in a top-down manner, where communities are not truly included?

Goal: To ensure that monitoring and evaluation systems are designed to prioritize accountability to project beneficiaries, not just donors, by integrating mechanisms that address local needs, prevent harm, and align success metrics with community-defined outcomes, while supporting sustainable funding and long-term project impact.

³⁴ The Racial Equity Index 64.

³⁵ Baguios, A., King, M., Martins, A. and Pinnington, R. (2021) [Link](#). 38.